Part Three:
Understanding Change

Session Three: **Understanding Change**

Introduction

People need to be motivated to change their behaviour. However, they are not always at a stage of readiness for change. If we try and impose change, through behaviour management strategies, for example, young people may not be ready or motivated to modify their behaviour and this can result in failure.

Aims

1. To help the young person develop an awareness of their own self-perception

2. To establish that our perceptions of who we are influence how we behave

3. To introduce the young person to patterns of changing behaviour

Activity 3a: **A film about me**

The idea of this exercise is to help the young person get an idea of how other people might see them. Through describing themselves as a film character, they are actually describing themselves in the third person. Some young people may find this difficult and may require extra guidance.

You will need

☑ Activity Sheet 3a *A film about me*
☑ Pen/pencil
☑ Coloured pens/pencils

What to do

- Ask the young person: *"If there was a film made about your life, what would [Name] be doing in the film? What type of character would [Name] be?"*

- Use Activity Sheet 3a and ask the young person to jot down or sketch ideas for a film about their life

- Use the boxes on the sheet as prompts

- As a supplementary activity, pupils could devise a short play or comic strip about their life using prompts from Activity Sheet 3a

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Activity 3b: **Changing your behaviour**

This exercise is designed to introduce the ideas that our self-perception influences how we behave and that in order to change behaviour we have to want to do so.

You will need

☑ Activity Sheet 3b: Changing your behaviour

What to do

- Either read through Activity Sheet 3b with the young person/people or allow them to read through it themselves, as appropriate.

- Discuss the questions below (also on Activity Sheet 3b). You may want to go through all of them or prefer to focus on certain ones. Record answers as appropriate.

Questions for discussion

Ask the young person:

- Have you ever made a new year's resolution? Did you keep it?

- How do you think people see you? (You may like to look at your film character sheet for ideas).

- What does 'being motivated' mean? What motivates you at school?

- What sorts of things do adults do when they think they have a behaviour that is a problem (e.g. drinking, smoking)? Look for responses that indicate the young person would seek help (e.g. look to friends, join a group) or increase resources available (e.g. buy nicotine patches, buy a book about how to be healthier).

- Who decides when behaviour might be a problem (e.g. school, parents)? Is it always you that decides when change is needed?

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Activity 3c: **Ashley's problem**

The aim of this activity is to introduce the young person to the Model of Stages of Change**.** This activity should be completed before moving to Part 4.

You will need

☑ Activity Sheet 3c (i) *Ashley's problem.* Choose the scenario relevant to the young person (i.e. whether Ashley is male or female)
☑ Activity Sheet 3c (ii) *Ashley's problem.* Blank response sheet
☑ Scissors and glue

What to do

- Two versions of this activity are offered where Ashley is male/female. This is to enable the facilitator to select the example most appropriate for the young person

- Read through Activity Sheet 3c with the young person then ask them to cut out the statements

- Ask the young person to organise the statements in order of how likely Ashley is to stop smoking, starting with the statement that suggests he/she is least likely to change

- Ask the young person to stick the statements onto Worksheet 3c (ii) in this order

- Discuss the young person's responses with them

Plenary

Ask the young person if they have found out anything they didn't really know about themselves today. With reference to Activity 3c, ask them if they could think of another behaviour that has different stages of change. What might these stages be?

Activity Sheet 3a: **A film about me**

What would the main character (you) be like?	
Props	Costume
Location (where it would take place)	Other people in the film
Other ideas	

Activity 3b: **A bit of psychology…**

Changing your behaviour

Some people think it's quite easy to change your behaviour! But wait a moment - what about new year resolutions? How many of our family and friends stick by theirs?

Change is not as easy as it sounds. There are actually six stages of change (but more about that later!)

There are lots of stages to go through when changing our behaviour. And sometimes we have good reasons not to change behaviours that teachers or family don't like. For example, fooling about in class might really annoy our teachers, but it can give our friends a good laugh. What our friends think about us can be very important.

Psychologists have found that our image of ourselves is very important to us. We actually look for information that supports the ideas we have about ourselves. For example, if you think of yourself as laid back, you will probably find yourself doing lots of laid back things and you will expect the people around you to think of you as laid back.

If you are someone who is thought of as having bad behaviour, people may expect you to behave badly in lessons. After a while, if you don't behave badly (for example, you work really well in a lesson you are interested in) people may be quite surprised. This can make changing our behaviour even harder!

In order to change our behaviour, we have to be motivated to do so. In other words, we have to want to do it! You may have heard stories of people who give up smoking or drinking after their doctors told them that their life was in danger. Other people lose weight or start exercising so they can look their best for a party or holiday. Young people may work harder and concentrate better during exam time if they need to get the right qualifications for the job they want.

It's not always easy to be motivated at school, particularly in a lesson that seems boring or we're not very good at. We can also feel less motivated when exams are a long way off or if we've got no real career plans. Sometimes in these situations we don't pay attention or bother with our homework. We might also get into trouble.

When our teachers and family get at us, this isn't always enough to make us want to change our behaviour. We need to be motivated to change! This means that we need to understand the benefits of changing.

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Activity 3b: **A bit of psychology…**

Questions for discussion

1. Have you ever made a New Year resolution? Did you keep it?

2. How do you think people see you? (You may like to look at your film character sheet for ideas)

3. What does 'being motivated' mean? What motivates you at school?

4. What sorts of things do adults do when they think they have a behaviour that is a problem (e.g. drinking, smoking)?

5. Who decides when behaviour might be a problem (e.g. school, parents)? Is it always you that decides when change is needed?

Activity Sheet 3c (i): **Ashley's problem**

Ashley has a problem with smoking.
Put the following statements in order according to how well Ashley is doing in terms of stopping smoking. Use worksheet 3c (ii) for this. Put the statement that suggests Ashley is least likely to change as number 1 and most likely to change as number 6.

Ashley told his friends today that he was never going to smoke again	Ashley has just bought some nicotine gum to help him stop smoking
Ashley enjoys smoking and doesn't realise it has become a habit	Ashley had stopped smoking three weeks ago, but he started again during his exams
Ashley saw an advert about how smoking can affect your health that worried him a bit	Ashley has managed not to smoke for a while now and feels more healthy

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Activity Sheet 3c (i): **Ashley's problem**

Ashley has a problem with smoking.
Put the following statements in order according to how well Ashley is doing in terms of stopping smoking. Use worksheet 3c (ii) for this. Put the statement that suggests Ashley is least likely to change as number 1 and most likely to change as number 6.

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Ashley saw an advert about how smoking can affect your health that worried her a bit	Ashley has managed not to smoke for a while now and feels more healthy

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Activity Sheet 3c (ii): **Ashley's problem**

Least likely to change

1.

2.

3.

4.

5.

6.

Most likely to change

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